FinMate AI
User Guide

A clear, practical guide to the fictional demo, private workspace, money forecast, and safety boundaries.

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Welcome

FinMate AI is a personal-finance workspace for recording income and spending, planning bills and category budgets, tracking savings goals, and viewing a transparent month-end estimate. It is an organisation and education tool, not financial advice.

Live website: https://finmate-ai-iota.vercel.app/

Two modes are intentionally available:

Mode	How to open it	Where data lives	Syncs between devices?
Fictional demo	Choose Explore fictional demo or visit `/app?demo=1`	Only in the current browser	No
Private cloud workspace	Create an account or sign in, then open `/app`	Your signed-in Supabase account	Yes

The demo has a visible FICTIONAL DEMO label. Its BDT figures are examples, not real accounts or real financial records.

Quick start

Explore safely without an account

1. Open the live website.
2. Select Explore fictional demo.
3. The Overview dashboard opens with sample income, spending, upcoming bills, budgets, and goals.
4. Use the left navigation on desktop, or the fixed bottom navigation on small screens. On mobile, choose More for Savings goals, FinMate AI, Activity, Settings, and Sign out.
5. In Settings, select Export JSON to download the fictional workspace, or Reset demo to restore the original sample data.

Demo data is deliberately browser-local. Clearing browser storage, changing browser profiles, or using another device will not move it to that device.

Use a private cloud workspace

1. On the landing page, select Create an account or Sign in.
2. Enter an email address and a password of at least eight characters.
3. For a new account, check your email and confirm it if Supabase email confirmation is enabled.

4. Sign in. Your first visit shows onboarding to choose currency, timezone, opening available balance, and an optional expected remaining-spending estimate.

5. Use Add transaction to begin your ledger.

The private workspace is designed to load and save the signed-in account's data through Supabase. Do not share an account with another person if you need separated financial records.

Navigation map

Place	What it does
Overview	Displays available balance, monthly income and expenses, unpaid bills, cash flow, forecast, budget pulse, and health signals.
Transactions	Your ledger. Search, filter, sort, add, edit, or delete ordinary income and expense entries.
Budgets	Sets monthly category limits and shows paid spending, remaining amount, and percentage used.
Bills	Holds future obligations. Marking a bill paid creates one linked expense entry.
Savings goals	Creates goals and records each contribution separately from the expense ledger.
FinMate AI	Explains the currently loaded workspace and can prepare a budget proposal for review.
Activity	Lists meaningful saved actions, including changes, bill payments, and approved budget proposals.
Settings	Controls display preferences, forecast inputs, categories, JSON export, and demo reset.

On desktop, Settings and Sign out sit at the bottom of the sidebar. On mobile, the fixed navigation shows Overview, Transactions, Budgets, Bills, and More. The More menu contains Savings goals, FinMate AI, Activity, Settings, and Sign out.

Understand the dashboard

The Overview page starts with four cards:

- Available balance: opening available balance plus recorded income minus paid expenses.
- Monthly income: income ledger entries dated in the current month.
- Monthly expenses: paid expense ledger entries dated in the current month.
- Unpaid bills: scheduled bills that are not yet marked paid.

The forecast is deliberately labelled Estimate, not a guarantee. It uses this calculation:

```
available now - unpaid bills - expected remaining spending = estimated month-end balance
```

If no custom expected-spending amount is entered, FinMate uses unspent category budgets as the remaining-spending assumption. Paid bills are linked to a ledger expense so that the same bill is not counted twice as both paid spending and unpaid money.

Record transactions

1. Select Add transaction from the header, or open Transactions.
2. Choose income or expense, description, amount, date, category, account, and recurrence where available.
3. Save the form. Totals and forecast update immediately.
4. On Transactions, use Search transactions, Filter type, Filter category, and Sort transactions to find entries.
5. Use the pencil button to edit a normal entry and the bin button to delete it.

Entries created by Mark paid in Bills are managed through Bills, not through the normal transaction editing controls. This protects the bill-payment link.

Create and review budgets

1. Open Budgets.
2. Under Add a category budget, select a category, enter a monthly amount, and choose the month.
3. Select Add budget.
4. Read the progress line: it shows spending, budget amount, amount left (or over), and percentage used.
5. Use Edit to change a budget or Delete to remove it.

A budget is a planning tool. It does not transfer money or create a transaction.

Plan bills without double counting

1. Open Bills.
2. Under Add a bill, enter the bill name, amount, due date, category, and frequency.
3. Choose Add bill.
4. When it is genuinely paid, select Mark paid beside that bill.
5. FinMate creates one linked expense in the ledger and updates the forecast.
6. If necessary, use Undo payment from the bill. Do not edit the linked expense directly.

Recurring bills remain scheduled reminders. They do not automatically create charges or payments.

Track savings goals

1. Open Savings goals.
2. Under Add a savings goal, enter a goal name, target amount, and optional target date.
3. Select Create goal.
4. For an existing goal, enter an amount under Contribution to [goal name] and select Add.
5. Review the goal percentage and contribution record below it.

Saving-goal contributions are separate records. They do not silently alter the income/expense ledger.

Use FinMate AI carefully

1. Open FinMate AI.
2. Read the Signals based on your current workspace.
3. Ask a short question in Ask FinMate AI, for example: “How do upcoming bills affect my estimate?”
4. Read the labelled response. It is explanatory and does not change data by itself.
5. To consider a change, select Draft a budget change. Read the proposed amount.
6. Select Approve change only if you agree, or Reject to discard it.

Without an optional AI provider key, FinMate uses a clearly labelled rules-based explanation that distinguishes greetings, category spending, bills, forecasts, savings goals, and unsupported questions. Forecast calculations remain deterministic either way. Do not treat any assistant response as regulated financial, legal, tax, or investment advice.

Settings, export, and privacy

In Settings you can:

- Change Currency for display.
- Change Timezone for date interpretation.
- Set Opening available balance and optional Expected remaining spending, then choose Save forecast settings.
- Add a New category. A custom category cannot be removed while a transaction, budget, or bill still uses it.
- Choose Export JSON for a device-local copy of the workspace currently loaded.
- In demo mode only, choose Reset demo to clear that browser's fictional sample workspace and restore samples.

An export is a convenience file, not an encrypted backup service. Store it carefully. The app never caches authenticated financial API responses in its offline service-worker cache.

Access from another device

1. On the other phone, tablet, or computer, open https://finmate-ai-iota.vercel.app/ in a modern browser.
2. Sign in with the same account to use the private cloud workspace.
3. Wait for the workspace to load before adding or editing records.

The same signed-in account is intended to load its Supabase-backed data across supported devices. The fictional demo is different: it is only stored in the browser where it was opened.

Install FinMate as a PWA

FinMate includes a web-app manifest, icons, service-worker registration, and an offline navigation page. Installation availability depends on the browser and operating system.

Android (Chrome or Edge)

1. Open the HTTPS live website.
2. Open the browser menu.
3. Choose Install app or Add to Home screen.
4. Confirm. FinMate opens like an app from the home screen.

iPhone and iPad (Safari)

1. Open the live website in Safari.
2. Tap Share.
3. Select Add to Home Screen.
4. Give it a name if desired, then select Add.

Windows, macOS, Linux, Chromebook

1. Open the HTTPS live website in a compatible Chromium browser such as Chrome or Edge.
2. Use the install icon in the address bar, or open the menu and choose Install FinMate AI / Install app.

PWA installation does not turn FinMate into an App Store or Play Store app. Offline mode is intentionally limited to the public app shell and offline page; it is not a way to access cloud financial data without a connection.

FAQ and troubleshooting

Why am I seeing “FICTIONAL DEMO”?

You opened demo mode, which is intentionally available without an account. It is safe for exploring. To use private cloud data, sign in and open `/app` without `?demo=1`.

Why does `/app` send me to sign in?

When cloud configuration is active, `/app` protects the private workspace. Sign in, or use Explore fictional demo for the labelled demo.

A cloud save did not complete. What should I do?

Check the internet connection, remain signed in, refresh after the connection returns, and retry the change. The interface shows a message if a queued cloud save fails.

Why does the assistant say “Rules-based fallback”?

That is expected when no optional provider key is configured, the provider is unavailable, or a request is rate-limited. Your finance dashboard continues to work.

Is my demo data private cloud data?

No. Demo data is fictional and browser-local. Do not put real sensitive financial records into the demo if you need cloud backup, cross-device access, or account protection.

Can FinMate give financial advice?

No. It provides calculations, planning views, and explanations based on recorded data. The forecast is an estimate, not a guarantee.

Known limitations

- A complete end-to-end sign-up and two-user RLS test should be performed with ordinary test accounts before relying on a new production configuration.
- Optional generative AI requires a separately configured server-side `OPENAI_API_KEY`; it is not required for the rules-based assistant.
- The app does not connect to banks, cards, or payment processors. All records are entered by the user.
- No custom domain is configured in this guide; the verified Vercel HTTPS URL is used.